

Since the tribe that a Nunnehi is connected to is so important to her role in society, we present here the barest touches of the histories of many of the human tribes of the Americas.

The Confederacy of the Iroquois

The Confederacy consisted of five nations, bound together by a shared language, customs, and laws, who lived in what later became New York state. The land was divided into five democratic republics that were governed by an elected council. Chiefs were elected from candidates proposed by matrons of the tribes, and could act only with the consent of all women of childbearing age. Women held most of the power in the Iroquois Nations because they maintained a matrilineal line, and because women tended to most of the work in the community, from child rearing to planting and harvesting. The men were often away for long stretches of time hunting.

Made up of the Mohawk, Oneida, Onondaga, Cayuga, and Seneca, the League of Five Nations became six when they allied with the Tuscarora. The Iroquois became the most powerful native tribes in the Northeast, allying with the European invaders and thus saving their lands and culture longer than many others. Unfortunately, during the Revolutionary War they sided with the British, and they did not fare as well after American victory in the war.

A few Cayugan Nunnehi still reside at Taughannock Falls, which serves as a place of power for them. They wait in vain for the return of their people, who now live on a reservation in northeastern Oklahoma. Of the six tribes, only the Seneca and Mohawk still maintain much presence in the area.

The Wabanaki Confederation

Wabanaki, which means "people of the dawn" is a confederation of five tribes: the Abeneki, Malisset, Passamaquoddy, Penobscot, and the Mi'kmaq, originally banded together to defend themselves against Iroquois aggression. Each tribe retained their own political leadership, but all five were Algonquin speakers and collaborated on issues such as diplomacy, war, and trade.

The Wabanaki allies were experts at canoeing, fishing, and trapping, and lived in wigwams covered in birch bark. The Calumet Ceremony, or peace pipe, was a ceremonial means to stop wars, mediate disagreements, and establish peace. Cured and softened beaver skins were a popular choice in clothing for all of the Confederation and were often traded with their French allies. The Maliseet were noted for their singing, dancing, and elaborate feasts, while the Penobscot found fame for their intricate bead and quill-work, and had a reputation for peacefulness and hospitality. Although the confederation officially disbanded in 1862, the five tribes remain close allies to this day, with most living on reservations in Maine.

Southeast

The tribes who inhabited the Southeast were mound-builders and hunter-gatherers who later turned to agriculture. They were known as the Cherokee, Choctaw, Chickasaw, and Creek. The Seminoles, offshoots of the Creek, eventually settled in the Florida peninsula. These tribes were hunters

and farmers, living in summer and winter towns and enjoying a complex form of government revolving around a chief and town council. Decisions were made by consensus, and both warriors and elders (known as beloved men and women) had a voice in the council.

Women played an important role in the life of the tribe. Societal structures were both matrilineal and matrilineal and women owned property, raised the children, and occasionally accompanied the warriors into battle as chroniclers and while singing songs to inspire the warriors. Intertribal warfare was common among these tribes, usually for the purpose of taking slaves and to assert status. In times of peace, warriors spent much of their time preparing for war and participating in ball games as practice. These games later assumed cultural significance among the tribes.

The Cherokee inhabited parts of the Carolinas, Tennessee, and Georgia. The Choctaw resided in southern Mississippi and parts of Alabama and Louisiana, while the Chickasaw claimed northern Mississippi as their home. The Creeks made their home in southern Georgia and Alabama, with the Seminole eventually splitting off to adapt to the semi-tropical environment of Florida.

Southwest

The tribes of the Southwest are mostly settled farmers who have adapted to the harsh desert environment. They are the originators of the rain dance and also the kivas. Originally pit houses dug into the sun-baked earth for shelter and as storage places, some kivas are sacred places where elders retreat to pray during important ceremonies. The ladder that emerged from inside to the roof of the kiva symbolized life emerging from the Earth Mother. Among those tribes are the Apache, Hopi, Navajo, and the Zuni.

The Apache were a nomadic people, hunting wild game and gathering wild plants. They lived in conical brush shelters called wickiups and sometimes planted corn and squash. The Apache dressed in deer skins and wore their hair loose and held by headbands. The men wore long breechcloths and soft, thigh-high moccasins. Today, there are 13 different Apache tribes: five in Arizona, five in New Mexico, and three in Oklahoma.

The Hopi are a peaceful people who were excellent farmers, known for being able to grow corn and other crops in the barren desert sands. Historically, Hopi women made pottery and baskets, while the men did the weaving and hunting. They lived in multistory pueblos made of adobe. A single house could contain dozens of units and house an entire extended clan. Today, most Hopi live on a reservation in northwestern Arizona where their ancestors have lived for thousands of years.

The Navajo came from northwestern Canada, and were hunter-gatherers before encountering the Pueblo peoples from whom they learned the farming of corn, squash, and beans. Later they learned silver making from the Spanish. The Navajo refer to themselves as the Dineh. Dineh women still wear their traditional colorful costumes, set off by silver and turquoise necklaces. They lived in hogans, domes of logs covered with mud, with a smoke hole at the top. Today, they are the second